

reliable communications, the very high altitudes of these satellites ensure that there is a noticeable delay in conversations. Also, the signals are much harder to pick up indoors.

The other alternative, lower Earth orbit satellites, manages to avoid these shortcomings. However, as the satellites travel extremely fast over the Earth's surface, a larger network of satellites is required to maintain constant connectivity.

Thuraya and Inmarsat satellite phones operate on geostationary orbit satellites. Thuraya provides complete connectivity to the Middle East, Asia and North Africa. Companies such as Iridium provide full global coverage using lower Earth-orbit satellites.

While an attractive alternative to mobile phones in rural areas, satellite phones continue to be unpopular due to their prohibitive costs. The cheapest handset with connectivity would today cost upwards of Rs. 40,000, plus a "large" monthly bill.



A Thuraya satellite phone